



MOMBASA 35,000 MANGROVES PROJECT REPORT



Theme: Future in a Million Trees

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

Youths for Green Action Kenya gratefully acknowledges the support of individuals, partners, and volunteers that made the Mombasa35000trees campaign a success.

Our donor (tagdev) and philanthropists provided essential financial support, while our partners, including the Mombasa County government, Ministry of Environment and Forestry, Kenya Forest Service, Kenya Wildlife Service, local community leadership, Egerton University administration and other invited partner higher learning institutions, provided logistical support and volunteer manpower.

We are especially grateful to the many volunteers who sacrificed their time and energy to help us plant 35,000 trees.

Above all, we give thanks to Almighty God for enabling us to plan and complete this successful project.

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INTRODUCTION

While high-level environmental debates may sometimes appear detached from grassroots concerns, the Youths for Green Action Kenya, is literally taking the fight to the roots where environmental leadership and climate action are most needed. The Organization's slogan for this project, "Dirty hands, clean environment," is no mere metaphor, but a reflection of the students' commitment to hands-on action.

In today's world, amid economic complexities, we all need constant reminders of our interconnectedness with Mother Nature. This act is essential, for a healthy planet is directly linked to human health and well-being, as well as the future of generations to come. Trees play an essential role in this, playing a critical role in mitigating climate change impacts and contributing to the health of the planet by acting as its lungs, drawing in carbon dioxide and releasing oxygen.

In the framework of the "Future in a Million Trees" planting project, the Youths for Green Action Kenya embarked on a mangrove restoration project in Mombasa County from September 24-28, 2023. Uniting under the belief in the cooperative value of unity, the Organization set out to plant 35,000 trees at Port Reitz creek. This campaign is a manifestation of young people's ability to contribute to a greater cause: sustaining the environment and developing a greener economy in the face of the climate crisis.

THE MOMBASA 35, 000 TREES PROJECT HIGHLIGHT.

The Mombasa 35,000 mangroves campaign brought together 120 volunteers from universities across Kenya, including Egerton University, Masinde Muliro University of Science & Technology, Technical University of Kenya, Jomo Kenyatta University of Agriculture & Technology, and Multimedia University. The campaign also involved more than 200 local community volunteers (including scouts), donors from TAGDEV, the office of the senator of Mombasa, the office of the women representative of Mombasa, partners from the Kenya Forest Service, Kenya Wildlife Service, Kenya Red Cross Society, Mombasa County Government, and Ministry of Environment Kenya, and media representatives.

On the 24th of September, 2023, participants from the Youths for Green Action Kenya and other higher education organizations arrived at the premises of the Wildlife Organization of Kenya in Shanzu, where they would stay for four days to fulfill their goal of rehabilitating the mangroves at **Port Reitz Creek**. Exuberant, cheerful, and resolved expressions were evident on their faces, reflecting their aspiration to drive environmental transformation.

OPENING CEREMONY

The official opening of the four-day tree planting campaign took place on September 25, 2023, and was attended by a diverse group of partners, including representatives from higher education institutions, government agencies, and donor organizations.

- Dr. James Owuor (Chairperson Greening Initiative-MMUST).
- Mr. Oscar Waswa (Assistant Registrar Student Affairs Department MMUST),
- Mr. Sayanga (Assistant County Commissioner) & Mr. Rama (Area Assistant Chief).
- Alfred Chamongoni – Chairperson Amani Mikoko Group
- Sergeant Hemedi Swaleh – Kenya Forestry Service Camp at Port Reitz Creek
- Corporal Augustus Segoi – Kenya Forestry Service Camp at Port Reitz Creek
- Youths for Green Action Kenya Board officials led by Miss Caroline and Mr. Daniel.
- Youths for Green Action Kenya Executive office led by Mr. Dennis Asiya (CEO).

TREE PLANTING

The mangrove tree planting restoration project was successfully conducted at **Port Reitz Creek**, Mombasa County, Kenya, **on September 25-26, 2023** at **Mchanjama, Maganda Village, Miritini Location in Jomvu Sub County**. Up to 35,000 mangrove seedlings procured from Amani Mikoko Group; a forestry community-based organization, were planted in two acres of land, with the participation of volunteers from the Organization, higher education institutions, local community members, and partners from government agencies and donor organizations. The restoration was gracefully opened by **Mr. Sayanga, Assistant County Commissioner, Miritini Division**.

The tree planting was a success on several fronts. First, it achieved its goal of restoring mangroves at Port Reitz Creek, which was largely destructed more so with the construction of **Dongo Kundu bridge** which passes through the mangrove forest. Second, it educated and engaged the local community in mangrove conservation. Third, it created a positive relationship between the volunteers and the local community members which impacted on the interconnectedness and social interrelationship skills to the student volunteers.

The volunteers were particularly enthusiastic about learning more on the importance of mangroves and how to plant and care for them. They also learned a lot from the local community members about mangrove conservation and traditional knowledge. Additionally, the volunteers were able to learn some Giriama and Chonyi words, which could help them to better their communication with the local community members as the project progressed, this enabled swift coordination of the restoration activity for the two days.

The mangrove restoration project at Port Reitz Creek is a model for other mangrove restoration projects in Kenya and around the world. It demonstrates the importance of collaboration between different stakeholders, including universities, government agencies, donor organizations, and local communities. The project also shows that mangrove restoration can be a successful and sustainable way to protect coastal ecosystems and mitigate the effects of climate change.



The Assistant County Commissioner (in boots) plants a tree as the project commences officially



The area Sub-Chief participating in mangrove plantation



A student volunteer drilling holes during the mangrove plantation



Student volunteers removing the polytubes from the seedlings



A volunteer showing his colleague on how to plant mangrove



Volunteers heading to pick seedlings

CLEAN UP ACTIVITY AT CHANGAMWE.

On September 27, 2023, a cleanup activity was held in **Changamwe Ward, Mombasa County, Kenya**. The activity was a collaboration between volunteers from Youths for Green Action Kenya and other organizations, more than 100 local community members, and local authorities led by the **Assistant County Commissioner of Changamwe Division, Mr. Nicholas Kaito**.

The goals of the clean-up activity were to clean up the community sports field and around the community social hall, and to educate the local community on solid waste management. Over 100 tons of solid waste were collected, and the local authorities and community members were educated on the definition of solid waste, types of solid waste, and ways to mitigate solid waste.

The clean-up activity was a success. The clean-up baraza was well-attended by the local authorities and community members. The volunteers were able to educate the local community on the importance of solid waste management and how to reduce, recycle, reuse, and dispose of solid waste properly.

This clean up activity is a model for other clean-up activities in Kenya and around the world. It demonstrates the importance of collaboration between different stakeholders, and the benefits of cleanup activities, such as improving public health and sanitation, segregation of solid wastes and reducing environmental pollution.

The project is a success story that shows what can be achieved when people come together to make a difference in their community.



A group photo of the volunteers and the locals settling down for the baraza cleanup



Student volunteer training the locals on solid waste management during the cleanup baraza



Loading of the collected solid wastes in the Mombasa County Government garbage collecting truck



A volunteer addressing the baraza on the importance of managing solid waste



A photo of the local authorities present during the cleanup baraza



Happy volunteers during the cleanup activity

TEAM BUILDING.

To ensure fruition of the whole team, we had to employ team building as an arsenal to achieve a cohesive and effective team of volunteers. It involved activities that helped volunteers to learn about each other, trust each other, and work together effectively. It impacted the volunteers and the whole team in the following ways;

- It helped build trust and communication among volunteers. To achieve the common goal of restoration and environmental conservation, volunteers needed to be able to trust each other and communicate effectively. The team building activities we held helped volunteers to develop these skills.
- It helped create a sense of camaraderie and belonging. Each volunteer felt part of the whole team, which made them motivated and engaged in their work. The team building items occasioned helped in creating a sense of community among the volunteers, thus success.
- It positively impacted on volunteer's leadership and problem-solving skills. Team building activities practiced required volunteers to work together to solve problems and achieve common goals. This helped volunteers to develop their leadership and problem-solving skills.
- The Team building helped volunteers to have fun and enjoy their volunteering experience where volunteers had time to relax and have fun, which could make their volunteering experience more enjoyable and rewarding.

A beach visit for the team building was a great way to achieve all of these goals. Beaches are often beautiful and relaxing places, which created a positive atmosphere for team building activities.



FOCUSED GROUP DISCUSSIONS.

As part of the youthful generation the volunteers also face a lot of challenges accruing from the sociocultural and economic dynamics being experienced on the face of the earth. On this note, the project program was developed in a manner to have focused group discussions where volunteers could discuss issues facing their life. Each group consisted of 12 volunteers led by a moderator.

These FGDs were used to gather in-depth information about volunteers' attitudes, beliefs, experiences, and opinions on various topics including Mental health, Culture, Entrepreneurship, Technology, Gender, Social Justice and Injustice. Where each Group could discuss depending on the topic assigned then present their outcomes in a general sitting before retiring for bed.

The FGDs were conducted in a semi-structured format, where the moderator had a list of questions to ask, but the discussion is allowed to flow naturally. The moderator encouraged his/her group members to share their thoughts and experiences, and to respond to each other's comments.



Group A



Group C



Group H



Group G

CLOSING CEREMONY.

The closing ceremony for the **Mombasa 35,000 mangrove** restoration project was a momentous occasion, and it was fitting that it was graced by the presence of the Coast regional coordinator for the Ministry of Youths, Arts and Sports – Mr. Ayako. The regional coordinator, in his address, commended the volunteers for their dedication and commitment to the project. He also highlighted the importance of mangrove restoration and the cleanup activity/ solid wastes management education conducted at Changamwe.

The regional coordinator then proceeded to award certificates of participation to the volunteers. This was a special moment for the volunteers, as it was a recognition of their hard work and their contribution to the project. The volunteers were proud to receive their certificates, and they were grateful for the opportunity to have participated in such a worthwhile project.



From left, Ass. County Commissioner - Mr. Nicholas Kaito, Ministry of Youth, Arts and Sports, Coastal Region Coordinator - Mr. Ayako, Olive Muthoni – Student Volunteer and Ministry of Environment Mombasa County Government Representative during certificate awarding session



ENCOUNTERS DURING THE PROJECT.

Mangrove restoration projects at the coastline can be challenging for volunteers especially those from inland who are not used to the coastline's climatic weather conditions. Here are some specific challenges we encountered:

Heat and humidity: The coastline is typically much hotter and more humid than inland areas. This happened to be a difficulty for the volunteers to adjust to, considering they are not used to working outdoors in hot weather.

Salt spray: Salt spray could irritate the skin and eyes. Volunteers were not used to working in salt spray, and this made us take extra precautions to protect ourselves. Like applying Vaseline or jelly.

Inadequate experience: Despite having the knowledge and being trained on how to plant the mangroves, volunteers had little and some with no any experience with mangrove planting or working in coastal environments.

Physical fitness: Mangrove planting can be physically demanding work. Many of the volunteers were not used to this type of work, and they needed to take extra precautions to avoid injury.

CONCLUSION.

The mangrove restoration project at the coast of Kenya was a success. Youths for Green Action Kenya Volunteers and coastal communities came together to plant 35,000 mangrove seedlings in a degraded mangrove ecosystem. These seedlings will grow to provide valuable coastal protection, biodiversity, and climate resilience for the communities that depend on them.

The project was particularly significant because it was conducted at the coast, where mangroves are essential for protecting coastal communities from storms and floods. Mangroves also provide a habitat for a variety of marine life, including fish, crabs, and shrimp. By restoring mangroves at the coast, volunteers helped to protect these important ecosystems and the communities that rely on them.

The mangrove restoration project is a long-term commitment, but the initial planting of mangrove seedlings is a significant step forward. With the help of volunteers and community support, the mangroves will continue to grow and thrive, providing a valuable resource for generations to come.

The clean-up activity and training on solid waste management awareness were complementary efforts that made a significant contribution to improving the environmental quality of Changanwe. By removing trash and educating the community about proper solid waste management, volunteers helped to create a cleaner, healthier, and more sustainable community. The clean-up activity and training on solid waste management awareness were also an opportunity for the community to come together and work towards a common goal. Volunteers and participants from all walks of life came together to make a positive impact in the community. This is a model for other communities around Kenya to follow

RECOMMENDATION.

Environmental sustainability is the ability to meet the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs. It is a complex issue that requires a global effort, but it is also something that individuals can contribute to in their own way.

While it is true that large corporations and governments play a major role in environmental degradation, we cannot ignore our own individual responsibility. We all have a role to play in protecting the environment and mitigating climate change.

We can also participate in environmental activism and advocacy. This could involve volunteering for an environmental organization, contacting our elected officials about environmental issues, or educating others about environmental sustainability. Every individual action, no matter how small, makes a difference. By working together, we can create a more sustainable future for ourselves and for generations to come. We all have a role to play in protecting the environment and mitigating climate change. We can all make small changes in our daily lives to reduce our impact on the environment. We can also support sustainable businesses and environmental organizations. And we can use our voices to advocate for environmental protection.

By working together, we can create a more sustainable future for ourselves and for generations to come.

PHOTO GALLERY





APPENDIX: YGAK GREEN ORGANIZATION, CONCEPT NOTE.

Introduction

The environment has limited natural resources with fragile life-support systems, and thus, can carry limited amount of burden. However, in the quest for economic progress and welfare, it is the environment that more often, gets compromised. Wide scale environmental degradation is the consequent result of society's insatiable appetite for growth and development. There is an urgent need to balance growth and development without putting a lot of burden on environmental resources.

The YGAK Green Organization, is a wholly youth-led Organization seeking to position the youths at the center of environmental action. The Organization believes that the youths have the capacity to drive change with regards to climate action agenda. The Organization ensures collaborative engagement with other Organizations, institutions of higher learning, corporate Organizations and individuals towards promoting environmental conservation.

Mission

We are dedicated to environmental improvements that foster a sustainable future and leads to social and economic empowerment in our communities.

Vision statement

We envision a clean, healthy, safe and sustainable environment in Kenya and beyond.

Aim

- i. To promote conservation and sustainable use of environment.

Major thematic areas

- i. Environmental education, research, awareness and outreach
- ii. Conservation leadership

Focus

Our major focus is achieving a sustainable environment by ensuring that the natural systems can continue to provide the natural resources and ecosystem services upon which the economy and society depend. We understand this is a process and we focus on approaching it from local and regional levels with emphasis on the environment.

Methodology

Focus is given to outreach projects and activities in our communities that aim at greening the environment; tree planting, solid waste management and creating environmental awareness. For all our established projects, we conduct follow up routines to ensure efficiency and long term impacts. We empower community generated projects through partnership to ensure maximum incorporation of community players in operations. Philanthropy stands out as a main vehicle towards promoting the well-being of humanity and cultivate the spirit of one society and its ability to solve its challenges.

Impact

We have had successful projects focused on building community resilience towards addressing challenges posed by climate change. We have carried out tree planting, youth leadership workshops, Environmental education in primary and high schools and stakeholder's meetings in the theme.

We have successfully planted over 200,000 tree seedlings in the Counties of Narok, Nakuru, Mombasa, Kakamega and Kisumu within three years of partnership, and collected over 100 tons of wastes in our different cleanup activities. Having been able to partner with different institutions, Organizations and individuals, has helped us gear towards achieving our goals and objectives. The Organization so far has also reached out to a million people through our activities and on our social media platforms.

Youths for Green Action Kenya is targeting to plant over 100,000 tree seedlings yearly, and corroborate with other higher learning institutions in Kenya to achieve this.

SUCCESSFUL PROJECTS CONDUCTED.

1. Mombasa Project (Theme: Action for sustainable city and community)

Conducted in 10th-14th January 2022, Youths for Green Action Kenya in partnership with the County Government of Mombasa carried out a community service in Bangladesh slums and Bangladesh Mangrove creek working closely with the Bangladesh elites Community Based Organizations, Linda



Mikoko Self Help Group and Big Ship Community Based Organization. Activities conducted included; clean up and sensitization of the community to promote community based environmental action, planting of 500 Mangrove trees along Bangladesh Mangrove site, capacity building workshop on climate action, and career and skills development.

2. Kakamega Project (Theme: *Future in a Million Trees*)

The Organization partnered with German Imaging Technologies (GIT), County Government of Kakamega, National Environment Management Authority (NEMA) and Masinde Muliro University of Science and Technology (MMUST) in an effort to improve rural, school and urban



environmental conditions and to educate and empower local communities on environmental concerns. The project was carried out between 26th-29th May, 2022 with external funding from German Imaging Technologies (GIT). Trees were planted in three sub-counties; Shinyalu, Ikolomani, and Lorambi. the specific targeted sites included Shitoli Polytechnic and Kambiri

Community in Shinyalu Sub-County, St Jerome Savane Polytechnic in Ikolomani and Bondeni primary in Lurambi Sub-County. A total of 10,000 tree seedlings were planted; 4000 Indigenous trees, 5700 exotic trees and 300 fruit trees.

3. World Environment Day (Theme: *Only One Earth*)

Youths for Green Action Kenya volunteers on 5th June 2022 joined the County Government of Nakuru Department of Environment and Natural Resources and other stakeholders in making the World Environment Day. On this day, the Organization together with other partners planted 5,000 trees in Menengai forest. The celebration was graced by Nakuru county Environment Chief Officer as the guest of honor.

4. August Tree Planting Challenge.

The Organization conducted a one-month tree planting challenge in the month of August 2022 ahead of the Kisumu project. This was one of the measures to increase the forest tree cover in Kenya. The campaign tasked YGAK ambassadors with planting trees in their respective residences, neighboring public spaces, and any other spots that they felt were appropriate for planting trees in their individual home counties. There was an open invitation to all ambassadors and all the participants were urged to invite their friends, family, and neighbors to attend and participate in the planting sessions with them. The challenge saw 1025 trees being planted in different regions of the country.



5. Kisumu Project

The County Government of Kisumu has committed to plant 40 million tree seedlings to help achieve the national afforestation agenda of planting at least 2 billion trees by 2022. To achieve this, the Organization joined the commitment by the Kisumu county government by planting a total of 5,000 tree seedlings within Kisumu town between 28th-30th October 2022. The Organization planted trees in various institutions including, Kenya Medical Training College- Kisumu main campus, Joyland Secondary school, Citam School Kisumu, ACK Shauri Moyo ward, and finally at The Mosque of Jesus Christ son of Mary. The Organization attracted diverse partners including Kisumu County Government- environmental Department, YGAK- volunteers from Masinde Muliro University, Kenyatta university, YGAK, the Technical

university of Kenya, Kenya Medical Training College- Kisumu main campus, Joyland special school, Citam Kisumu, ACK shauri Moyo, and The Mosque of Jesus Christ Son of Mary.

6. Run for the Mau.

This is an annual event organized by YGAK for the rehabilitation of Njoro

River. The Organization partnered with the university and other cooperate Organization in ensuring a commitment towards rehabilitation of the river. The Organization committed to plant 1000 trees to facilitate the event which were planted on 7th April 2023.



7. Narok 100,000 Trees

YGAK Green Organization, was allocated 110 acres of land in Chebitat forest, to push its regeneration and conservation agenda. The Organization was specifically allocated Plot No. 23 in the Mau Forest land. Volunteers engaged in planting trees every morning with a target of at least 60 tree seedlings per person per day which the volunteers embraced so



well with different donors happily joining in the activity. The sloppy terrain in the forest did not hinder the volunteers who were excitedly determined to accomplish their daily targets.

OTHER ACTIVITIES.

The Organization has engaged in different capacity building activities/workshops to ensure that the volunteers are up to date with the current environmental trends. We have also been nominated to environmental champion competitions like the Hummingbird Awards where we won different tree seedlings and seed-balls to help foster our mission. Bringing the volunteers together through different occasions like climate action seminars, teambuilding activities, workshops and talks has been key to ensure that we keep up with our enthusiasm.

GLANCE IMPACT.

- Conducted 20 projects
- Planted over 200,000 trees in different parts of the country
- Collaboration - On boarded the following partners: German Imaging Technologies, Watu Gadi YGAK, NEMA, county governments, Kenya Forest Services
- Monitoring and Evaluation- we monitored and evaluated the impact of the initiatives and projects carried out during the year. This we believe will help the Organization understand what is working well and what can be improved to achieve its goals more effectively
- Creation of Awareness - The has invested its efforts on raising awareness on environmental issues among the public especially in schools. We believe this will help build support for the initiatives and increase its impact

CHALLENGES

- Limited resources, including funding and equipment makes it difficult for the Organization to carry out its initiatives and projects effectively. The Organization however has been keen in forming constructive collaborations quickly whenever they want to carry out a project to facilitates its smooth running. The Organization continues to call upon more partners who support their agenda to help them achieve its goals.
- Limited public awareness among YGAK ambassadors. Despite the efforts by the Organization to raise awareness of its activities, the general public is still not well- informed of its operations.